

Restructuring D11 Food & Nutrition Services

A Chef-Director Model for Colorado Springs School District 11

Prepared by Emma Moore · May 12, 2026 · Enclosure to correspondence with the El Paso County Board of County Commissioners, the Colorado Commissioner of Education, and the D11 Board of Education

Executive Summary

Colorado Springs School District 11 can feed approximately 22,265 students better food, pay kitchen workers higher wages, reduce staff turnover, and lower the office-overhead share of its Food & Nutrition Services budget — by consolidating duplicate management positions and elevating a credentialed chef to lead the department. This is the model successfully deployed at Boulder Valley School District (BVSD) under Chef Ann Cooper, a Colorado district of comparable scale (approximately 30,000 students, 56 schools) with a documented 15+ year track record.

The proposal asks the D11 Board of Education to authorize a Food Service Strategic Review, restructure the FNS organizational chart around a Chef-Director role, and commit to a three-year transition plan with public quarterly reporting.

Why this, why now

D11's Food & Nutrition Services is funded overwhelmingly by public dollars: federal National School Lunch and School Breakfast Program reimbursements, Colorado's Healthy School Meals for All (HSMA) program established by Proposition FF, and USDA commodity entitlement. Statewide HSMA reimbursements totaled **\$162,062,094** in FY 2023-24. D11's share of Colorado K-12 enrollment is approximately 3 percent, placing estimated HSMA reimbursement to D11 in the **\$4–5 million** range annually, on top of federal NSLP/SBP dollars and local revenue.

The FY 2024-25 Adopted Food Service Fund began at \$2,862,063 for specific line items and grew, after two board amendments, to \$4,038,623 in expenditures with a \$530,000 deficit. The full Food Service Fund — including all salaries, benefits, and food across 58 kitchens — is materially larger; the complete schedule appears in the FY25 Adopted Budget Book on D11's financial transparency page.

Current state: the structural issue

D11's published FNS leadership office consists of twelve named positions overseeing kitchen managers and staff across 58 school sites:

Position	Function
Director of FNS	Department head; USDA compliance; Board reporting
Assistant Director (1)	Operations / kitchens

Assistant Director (2)	Program / compliance
Business Manager	Federal claims, indirect cost rate, AP/AR
Procurement Specialist	Vendor contracts, USDA commodities
Area Supervisor (1)	~29 school kitchens
Area Supervisor (2)	~29 school kitchens
Technology Specialist	POS / LINQ Connect / meal accounting
Free & Reduced Coordinator	Eligibility, applications, state reporting
D11 Chef	Currently bottom-of-chart; no purchasing authority
Office Staff (3)	Admin support

Using public salary benchmarks for K-12 food service roles — national median Director of Food & Nutrition Services approximately \$102,280 per salary.com, with Assistant Directors \$85K–105K, Business Manager \$70K–95K, Procurement Specialist \$55K–75K, Area Supervisors \$50K–70K, and Chef \$55K–85K — this office layer plausibly runs **\$1.15M–\$1.45M annually in salary plus benefits**, before any kitchen worker is paid and before any meal is served.

Two structural problems. First, three layers of supervision (Director → 2 ADs → 2 Area Supervisors) over what is functionally one operating department. Second, the role with the most direct expertise in food quality, sourcing, and waste reduction — the Chef — sits at the bottom of the org chart with no purchasing authority, no system-level menu authority, and no vendor selection authority.

Proposed model: Chef-Director restructure

Collapse the top three layers into a Chef-Director role leading the department. Combine the two Assistant Director positions into a single Director of Operations managing the kitchens. Retain the Business/Compliance Manager — federal claims paperwork is a real job that cannot be eliminated. Evolve the Procurement role into a Local Sourcing & Procurement Specialist measured on HSMA local food purchasing grants captured. Reduce two Area Supervisors to one. Retain the Free & Reduced Coordinator, Technology Specialist, and one to two office staff.

New Position	Function
Chef-Director	Department head; menu, sourcing, training; USDA compliance (with credential or via Business Manager)
Director of Operations	All 58 kitchens, staffing, supervisor management
Business / Compliance Manager	Federal claims, indirect cost rate, AP/AR
Local Sourcing & Procurement Specialist	Vendor contracts, USDA commodities, HSMA local food grants
Area Supervisor	All school kitchens, single supervisor
Technology Specialist	POS / LINQ Connect / meal accounting
Free & Reduced Coordinator	Eligibility, applications, state reporting
Office Staff (1–2)	Admin support

That is twelve positions down to eight or nine, with the top role paid materially better to attract a chef-administrator combining a culinary background with either an SNS (School Nutrition Specialist) credential or commitment to earn one within 18 months for federal compliance.

Year-1 office savings (illustrative)

	Estimate
Current office payroll + benefits (midpoint)	~\$1,300,000
Proposed office payroll + benefits	\$950,000 – \$1,000,000
Net annual office savings	\$300,000 – \$350,000

These figures are illustrative. The actual numbers reside in the FY25 Adopted Budget Food Service Fund schedule and in District payroll records (PeopleSoft, transitioning to PowerSchool BusinessPlus). A Colorado Open Records Act request can produce them.

Where the savings go

Savings should not return to the General Fund. They should reinvest where they create compounding value:

Kitchen-worker wage increase (\$150K–\$200K of savings). Colorado's HSMA program already provides a state stipend specifically for raising wages of food preparation and service workers — Proposition FF money. D11 layers a local raise on top. School food service turnover nationally runs 30–40 percent annually; bringing it under 20 percent saves real recruiting and training cost.

Scratch-cooking training and equipment (~\$100K, Year 1). Most school kitchens are equipped to reheat, not cook. Investment covers combi ovens, prep tables, knives and cookware, and training cohorts at central kitchens. The Chef Ann Foundation provides off-the-shelf curriculum and consulting for exactly this transition.

Local sourcing pilot (~\$50K + HSMA local food grants). Begin with one product category — bread, eggs, or produce — sourced from Pikes Peak region farms. The Colorado HSMA Local Food Purchasing Grant program underwrites the price differential during transition.

Compounding savings in Years 2–4

Scratch cooking, run competently at scale, typically cuts food cost 10–15 percent versus pre-packaged after a 12–18 month learning curve. On a \$5M–\$6M food spend, that yields **\$500K–\$900K annually in recurring food-cost savings**, available for reinvestment in food quality, expanded local sourcing, or reducing the periodic Food Service Fund deficit.

Reduced waste is a separate savings line. Most district-level audits find waste at 20–35 percent of served food; cutting that in half effectively recovers meals the federal reimbursement already paid for.

Risks and how to handle them

Federal compliance

The Chef-Director requires the SNS credential or a Business/Compliance Manager who holds it. The proposed structure preserves the compliance function. USDA Buy American provisions, allergen accommodations, and claims paperwork do not disappear — they are performed by the right specialist.

ESP / classified union protections

Any restructure must respect the existing Master Agreement. The approach is attrition and reorganization on retirement or resignation, not termination. Position eliminations occur at the Assistant Director level, where the District has greater flexibility. Existing leadership is offered the Director of Operations role or transition support.

Year-1 transition cost

Real, and estimated at \$200K–\$400K covering training, equipment, Chef-Director search costs, and outside consulting. This is why the proposal is a three-year ROI, not a Year-1 windfall.

Federal indirect cost rate

Restructuring affects the indirect cost calculation. Coordinate with CDE's School Nutrition Unit before finalizing.

Implementation phases

Phase	Timeline	Activity
Phase 0	Months 0–3	Board authorizes Strategic Review. Hire external consultant (Chef Ann Foundation or equivalent) for operations audit. Publish findings. Vote.
Phase 1	Months 4–12	Recruit and hire Chef-Director. Existing Director transitions or exits with severance. Run 6-school scratch-cooking pilot. Capture baseline food cost and waste data.
Phase 2	Year 2	Roll out to 20 schools. Lock in local sourcing contracts. Year-2 budget shows food cost trend.
Phase 3	Year 3	Full district rollout. Audit, adjust, publish results.

What the D11 Board is being asked to approve

One. Authorize the Strategic Review and consultant engagement (estimated \$50K line item).

Two. Direct the Superintendent to prepare a restructured FNS organizational chart with proposed Chef-Director role and revised compensation schedule, returning to the Board within 90 days.

Three. Commit, conditional on the review, to a three-year Chef-Director transition plan with public quarterly reporting on food cost, meal participation, kitchen-worker retention, and student satisfaction.

Closing argument

Boulder Valley School District has operated this model for more than fifteen years. With approximately 30,000 students and 56 schools, BVSD is comparable in scale to D11. Their kitchen workers are paid better. Their kids eat scratch food made with regional ingredients. Their Director travels nationally to teach other districts how to do it. There is no compelling reason Colorado Springs students should eat worse than Boulder students, and there is a clear, replicable playbook for closing the gap.

Public sources referenced

- [D11 Food & Nutrition Services Office Contacts](https://d11.org/administration/operations/school/food-and-nutrition-services/fns-office-contacts) — d11.org/administration/operations/school/food-and-nutrition-services/fns-office-contacts
- [D11 Adopted Budget & Financial Transparency](https://d11.org/administration/operations/financialservices/financial-transparency/required) — d11.org/administration/operations/financialservices/financial-transparency/required
- FY 2024-25 Food Service Budget Amendments #1 (Dec 2024) and #2 (May 2025) — D11 BoardDocs
- Colorado HSMA Program — cde.state.co.us/nutrition/healthy-school-meals-for-all-program
- HSMA FY 2023-24 statewide reimbursement total of \$162,062,094 — CDE Joint Budget Committee briefing, 9/19/24
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Author

Emma Moore
pivotrtruenorth.com · linkedin.com/in/emmamore · 310-913-8931